

THE ONE IDEA

The world splits into **ordered** systems, where cause and effect are knowable in advance, so you analyze then act; and **unordered** systems, where cause and effect are visible only afterward, so you act then learn. The fatal error is treating an unordered problem as if it were ordered.

Anchor: the playground

One scene, four states. Notice the shift from **equipment** (a slide, a play structure) in the ordered domains to **children** (recess, an injury) in the unordered ones. That shift is the lesson: ordered problems are about things you can engineer; unordered problems are about living systems you can only shape and respond to.

▲ UNORDERED · ACT AND LEARN YOUR WAY FORWARD

Complex

Probe → Sense → Respond

EMERGENT PRACTICE · KIDS AT RECESS

No right answer up front. Run a small, safe-to-fail experiment, watch what emerges, then amplify what works and dampen what doesn't.

EVERYDAY	Hosting a party; you set conditions but cannot script how it unfolds.
IR	Hunting a novel adversary; you test hypotheses and follow what you find.
PARENTING	Raising a teen; you shape values, you cannot dictate the outcome.
AI GOV	Governing emergent model behavior; pilot, monitor, adjust policy.
IT / SEC	Shifting a team's security culture; rolling out a new way of working.



Complicated

Sense → Analyze → Respond

GOOD PRACTICE · A BIG PLAY STRUCTURE

A knowable answer that needs expertise to find. Experts may reasonably disagree on the route; there is more than one good way.

EVERYDAY	Baking a soufflé; hard, but a skilled cook knows how.
IR	Forensic analysis of a known malware family; methodical, expert-led.
PARENTING	Helping with calculus homework; a hard but solvable problem.
AI GOV	Building a model risk assessment to an established standard.
IT / SEC	Diagnosing why a server cluster is slow; a complex audit.



Chaotic

Act → Sense → Respond

NOVEL PRACTICE · AN INJURY ON THE PLAYGROUND

No time to analyze, no stable patterns. Act immediately to stabilize, then assess. The goal is to get back to a domain where you can think.

EVERYDAY	A grease fire on the stove; you act first and reason later.
IR	Active ransomware detonating; isolate and contain now, investigate later.
PARENTING	A child is hurt; you respond instantly, then sort out what happened.
AI GOV	A model causing live harm; pull it offline first, root-cause after.
IT / SEC	A major outage or active breach in progress.



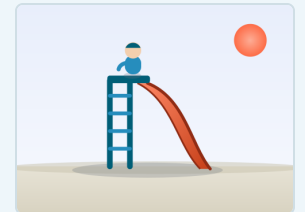
Clear

Sense → Categorize → Respond

BEST PRACTICE · FORMERLY "OBVIOUS / SIMPLE" · A SINGLE SLIDE

Cause and effect are obvious to everyone. Recognize the category and apply the known rule. There is one right answer.

EVERYDAY	Following a familiar recipe for spaghetti.
IR	A phishing report that matches a known pattern; run the playbook.
PARENTING	Bedtime routine; the same steps work every night.
AI GOV	Applying a settled acceptable-use rule to a clear-cut request.
IT / SEC	A password-reset ticket; a documented runbook step.



▼ ORDERED · ANALYZE FIRST, THEN ACT

Disorder (center)

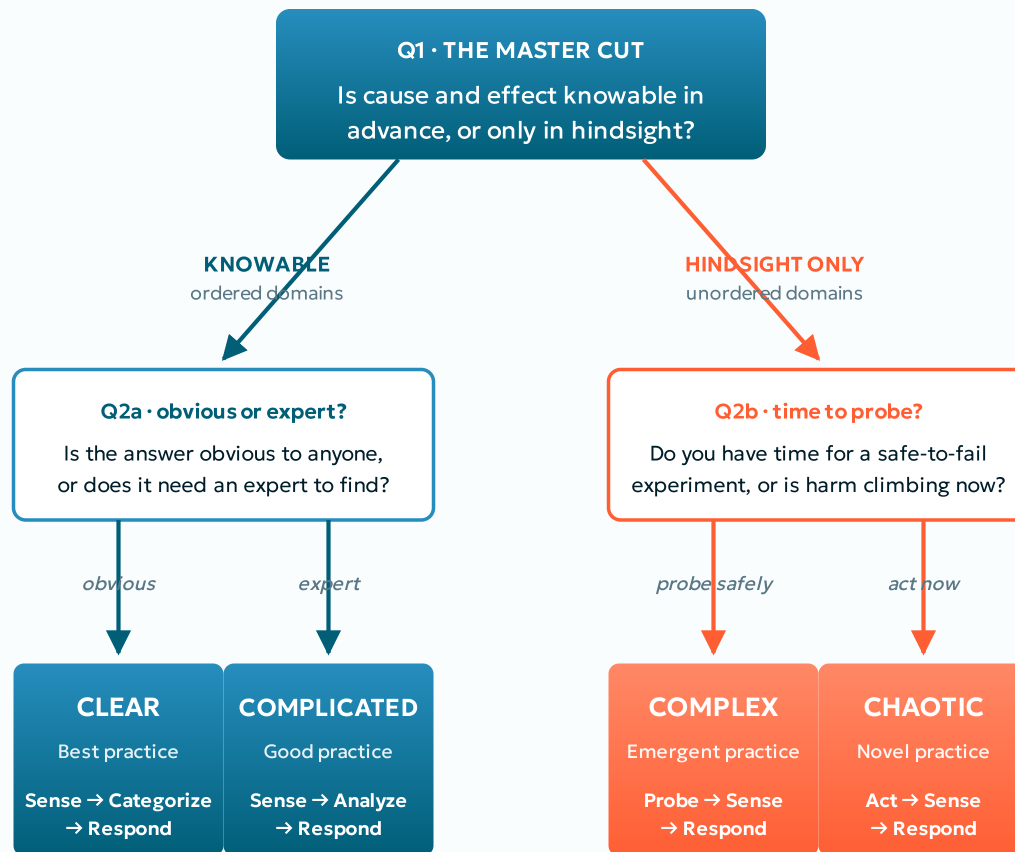
You don't yet know which domain you're in. **Break the situation into parts and assign each part to a domain.** The trap: people default to their comfort zone; the rule-follower forces everything into *Clear*, the specialist forces everything into *Complicated*.

Memory hook: as you move from order to disorder, the **thinking step migrates to the back** (Categorize, then Analyze, then Sense-after-probe, then Act-first). The Clear–Chaotic edge is a **cliff**; complacency makes you fall, it does not let you drift.

THE PREMISE

You don't determine the domain by staring at the problem; you determine it by *probing how the problem behaves*. Cause and effect is something you test, not something you eyeball. Run these three questions in order.

THE THREE-QUESTION DIAGNOSTIC



A FAST PROXY FOR Q1

If several competent people would converge on the same answer, you're in **ordered territory** and analysis will work.

If each would have to try things and see, you're in **unordered territory**; analysis will fail. Act and observe instead.

BEHAVIORAL SIGNATURES

Real-world tells; if you find yourself doing one of these, the domain is announcing itself.

Clear	You want to write a checklist; it actually holds.
Complicated	You're convening experts and building an analysis.
Complex	Every plan you make gets invalidated by reality; the problem keeps changing.
Chaotic	No time to think; the cost of inaction is climbing by the minute.

WATCH YOUR OWN BIAS

Under uncertainty, you'll classify the problem into **whichever domain you're personally most comfortable in**. The rule-follower forces a checklist on a complex mess. The expert over-analyzes what needed a quick probe. The crisis-junkie escalates a manageable situation to chaos. If your diagnosis happens to land on the response you were always going to prefer, be suspicious of it.

DECOMPOSE BEFORE YOU CLASSIFY

Most substantial problems are not one domain; they are a bundle. A ransomware incident is **chaotic** at the moment of detonation, **complicated** during forensic analysis, and **complex** when you're trying to change the human behaviors that let it in. Break the situation into parts and assign each part its own domain. This is exactly what Snowden means by moving out of *Disorder*.

DEFAULT RULE

When you genuinely can't tell complex from complicated, treat it as **complex** and run a small safe-to-fail probe. The asymmetry: if you treat complex as complicated, you commit to a confident plan that fails expensively. If you treat complicated as complex, your probe reveals the answer quickly and cheaply. The downside of guessing wrong on the cautious side is small; on the confident side it can be a cliff.